Housing and Sustainable Communities Policy

The Green Party will ensure people's right to healthy, secure housing. We will focus on: launching a massive public housing project that is funded, managed and run by the government; providing for a substantial increase in Māori housing and the removal of barriers to Māori housing; making housing accessibility and safety for disabled people a high priority; reducing building-related greenhouse gas emissions; and creating frameworks to ensure regenerative urban development that connects people within their communities.

Vision

Accessible, healthy, secure and sustainable housing for all in thriving communities.

Values and Principles

This housing policy must be consistent with the following values and principles:

- *Honour Te Tiriti o Waitangi*: Article 2 of Te Tiriti o Waitangi guarantees tangata whenua tino rangatiratanga over their taonga, which includes their whenua. Honouring this guarantee is fundamental to enabling housing developments, including papakāinga. Funding should be prioritised for Māori housing developments, with ownership and decision-making by Māori. Mātauranga Māori principles of design for housing and communities should be broadly applied across the whole housing sector to build adequate housing for all.
- *Ecological Wisdom*: Our communities must be life-sustaining. They should be designed, built or renovated using principles, materials and processes that are regenerative and minimise negative environmental impacts.
- *Social Responsibility:* People should have access to healthy, affordable and secure homes that support wellbeing and enable connected, inclusive communities. Housing needs to be designed as universally accessible so that all groups in the community have equitable access to appropriate and affordable housing.
- *Appropriate Decision-Making:* Communities should be actively involved in decisions that affect the places they live. Decision-making should particularly consider the interests of those who have been marginalised, and actively ensure their inclusion in community engagement processes.
- *Non-Violence*: Vested private interests that seek to maintain control of housing should be mitigated by the government through legislation and engagement to neutralise the power imbalance. No one should be forced to move out of their home without a suitable alternative being provided.

- *Decommodification:* Housing should be seen as a fundamental human need and right, not something that is traded for capital gains and profits that serve to perpetuate inequality. Basically, houses should be homes.
- *Housing security:* People should be able to live in their home or community for as long as they wish, regardless of ownership. Having generations of family/whānau living together contributes to stable and healthy communities.
- *Housing for disabled people:* Disabled people have the right to live in accessible housing both wherever and with whomever they choose to live.

Strategic Priorities

The Green Party's strategic goals include:

> *"Healthy homes within thriving neighbourhoods will be available to everyone. People will be part of caring communities with a strong heritage fabric and easy access to the natural environment."*

Actions in this policy that will help achieve this include:

- Sufficiently resourcing papakāinga and other Māori-led housing solutions and Māori community housing providers (1.2.1)
- Establishing a right to housing in legislation that requires the State to ensure all New Zealanders are adequately housed in safe, healthy, accessible, affordable housing. (2.1.1)
- Establishing a Ministry for Green Works to ensure supply of suitable housing for all New Zealanders (...) (3.4.1)
- Establishing representative housing committees in all local communities that reflect both homeowners and renters (4.6.2)
- Creating regulatory structures, including affordable housing requirements, that require developers to provide for equitable developments. (4.3.2)

Connected Policies

To address the housing crisis, alongside the actions below the Government in the Economy must incentivise productive Business investment and savings to support Livelihoods, and disincentivise property speculation. Sustainable development is an important part of protecting Biodiversity and Environmental Regeneration, including restoring urban Freshwater ecosystems. Key to sustainable development are minimising suburban sprawl in favour of regenerative Land Use and Soils, reducing the impacts of Climate Change, minimising Energy use, enabling and prioritising low-carbon Transport, and focusing on Community in the Economy. See our Kaupapa Māori Policy for pathways for returning Māori ancestral lands to Māori ownership.

Policy Positions

1. Honouring Te Tiriti o Waitangi and Hoki Whenua Mai

Issues

Dispossession of land has created deep, intergenerational harm for many Māori communities that goes far beyond the initial physical loss of whenua. Its loss underpins higher rates of Māori

poverty, unemployment, and insecure or overcrowded housing in many regions. Dispossession often forced Māori to relocate, breaking up hapū and disrupting traditional support structures. It also meant loss of decision-making power over the use of whenua. There are still barriers to and breaches of tino rangatiratanga, which guarantees the right of Māori to build and house their people on their own land.

Actions

1.1. Ensure all government agencies with responsibility for housing are fully responsive to Māori housing priorities, including by:
   1.1.1. Establishing a co-governance model at the Ministry of Housing and Urban Development and Kāinga Ora, and promoting co-governance structures for all new housing developments through Kāinga Ora;
   1.1.2. Encouraging mātauranga Māori-informed designers to be involved from the formative stages across all housing development to honour Te Tiriti; and
   1.1.3. Partnering with Māori to determine the need for and implement a Māori Housing Authority.
1.2. In partnership with Māori, empower Māori-led solutions for secure, affordable housing in all areas of the country by:
   1.2.1. Sufficiently resourcing papakāinga and other Māori-led housing solutions and Māori community housing providers;
   1.2.2. Providing easy-to-access pathways to housing ownership for all Māori, including from the rental market;
   1.2.3. Delivering targeted programmes providing culturally appropriate housing for homeless tamariki and rangatahi Māori and hapū tāngata and their whānau;
   1.2.4. Identifying and removing barriers to housing development by Māori for Māori, especially those that affect building on Māori land; and
   1.2.5. Reaching out to all Māori experiencing housing stress.
1.3. Seek to return whenua Māori to Māori ownership and restore the rights of Māori as its kaitiaki, including by:
   1.3.1. Returning Crown land reserved for Māori into Māori ownership, starting with land that supports the resilience of our communities;
   1.3.2. Including the return of Māori land in climate change adaptation and heritage protection programmes;
   1.3.3. Restoring the powers of the Waitangi Tribunal to make recommendations in relation to privately owned land;
   1.3.4. Establishing a fund, proportional to accumulated land value loss, to enable whānau, hapū, and/or iwi to reacquire dispossessed Māori land when it becomes available;
   1.3.5. Upholding the Right of First Refusal of purchase for Māori ancestral land that is released by the Crown;
   1.3.6. Ending perpetual leases of Māori-owned land;

1.3.7. Amending the Public Works Act to prevent compulsory acquisition of Māori customary land and Māori freehold land, as defined in the Te Ture Whenua Māori Act; and

1.3.8. Support Māori to settle land disputes and challenges using tikanga Māori-led processes.

2. Housing as a Public Good and Basic Right

Issues

House buying and renting are increasingly unaffordable for many. Thousands of mainly low-income and other housing-marginalised New Zealanders do not have adequate housing, living unhoused or in cars, motels, camping grounds, or overcrowded or substandard housing. Housing is often inappropriate for marginalised groups, including disabled people and people from communities in which large, extended families live together. Inadequate housing leads to adverse health outcomes. This housing crisis, rooted in the commodification of housing, is exacerbated by land banking and vacant, underutilised housing stock.

Actions

A. Housing as a Human Right

2.1. Treat housing as a human right by:

2.1.1. Establishing a right to housing in legislation that requires the State to ensure all New Zealanders are adequately housed in safe, healthy, accessible, affordable housing; and

2.1.2. Supporting those at high risk of facing housing disadvantage to be fully housed in the communities of their choice.

2.2. Ensure that homelessness is rare, brief, and non-recurring by:

2.2.1. Providing healthy, safe and accessible permanent housing to unhoused people in a way that upholds autonomy and dignity;

2.2.2. In cases where permanent housing is not appropriate, providing adequate shelters and facilities; and

2.2.3. Adopting a housing-first approach with wrap-around support for people who have both housing needs and other complex needs, including those who have been evicted or had to leave their home due to domestic violence.

2.3. Provide disabled people with equitable choices about where they live, including by:

2.3.1. Providing support to transition from residential services to living in the community; and

2.3.2. Providing timely, transparent, needs-based funding for housing modifications, including for people living in papakāinga.

2.4. Decommodify the housing market by:

2.4.1. Investigating capping the number of houses that may be bought by an individual, private company, or family estate; and

2.4.2. Introducing a value uplift levy where rezoning, the provision of public transport and/or other public works result in increased land development potential.

B. Public housing

2.5. Ensure that everyone who does not own their own home has access to adequate public housing by:

2.5.1. Protecting, enhancing and expanding public housing stock;

2.5.2. Phasing out means-testing and background-testing for public housing as more public housing stock is built;

2.5.3. Giving priority for public housing to people who are living in poor accommodation and those at high risk of extremely poor outcomes;

2.5.4. Making Kāinga Ora a government department rather than a Crown entity to ensure a focus on service to the public, and reorienting its activities to significantly increase public housing supply;

2.5.5. Opposing any privatisation of public housing, including public housing land; and

2.5.6. Creating public, purpose-built, rent-assisted living units for older people in all areas that maintain community inclusiveness.

2.6. Ensure the approach to developing new public housing:

2.6.1. Fully honours Te Tiriti;

2.6.2. Uses high-quality urban design and built environments, centering new housing developments around pre-existing communities and enabling social connections in public housing areas; and

2.6.3. Maximises the proportion of housing supply from public and Māori housing, by increasing the availability of government, council, community and iwi-provided housing, aiming for universal public housing for all.

2.7. Support and partner with community housing groups whose objectives and methods align with the principles outlined in our policy, including by:

2.7.1. Providing direct government funding for public and community housing projects, avoiding the use of private funding such as leveraging.

C. Rental housing

2.8. Expand the rights of renters by:

2.8.1. Requiring all rental tenancies to be offered as long-term or permanent tenancies;

2.8.2. Mandating that disabled people must have an accessible house to move into before ending a tenancy;

2.8.3. Establishing a rental warrant of fitness system that guarantees affordable, healthy rental homes; and

2.8.4. Allowing renters to have pets, subject to any restrictions aimed at protecting wildlife.

2.9. Improve oversight and compliance of landlords delivering on their obligations to tenants, including by:

2.9.1. Creating a register for landlords and property managers;

2.9.2. Supporting and enabling efforts (such as renters' unions and more legal protections) for renters to take direct action against corporate and bad-acting landlords to demand better conditions and affordable rents; and

2.9.3. Reviewing the Tenancy Tribunal system to ensure it is accessible and balanced for renters and that their privacy is protected.

2.10. Ensure that rents are affordable, including by:

2.10.1. Expanding the Income-Related Rent Subsidy to councils;

2.10.2. Implementing rent controls that limit rent increases to whichever is lower of inflation and average wage increases; and

2.10.3. Limiting the loss of rental accommodation to short-term visitor accommodation.

3. Sustainable Buildings

Issues

Since the early 1990s, housing construction has trended toward larger, expensive homes, while failing to provide enough affordable, accessible homes. Construction produces high carbon emissions and waste, and supplier monopolies exacerbate supply and affordability issues. Land has been used inefficiently, causing urban sprawl, rising land prices, and greater infrastructure needs. Many of the 1.8 million existing houses, especially rentals, are substandard and lack resilience to climate change, natural hazards and utility disruptions.

Actions

3.1. Ensure, through regulation and standards, that buildings and their surroundings are designed, constructed, renovated and repurposed to provide:

3.1.1. Efficient and effective heating and cooling of buildings;

3.1.2. Water conservation;

3.1.3. Resilience against natural hazards, including identifying and preparing for climate change-related threats, and outages of network utilities;

3.1.4. Universal access and design;

3.1.5. For the physical and mental wellbeing of communities and residents of buildings, including the safety of disabled people in an emergency;

3.1.6. Safe access by active and public transport, including at night;

3.1.7. Minimal embodied and operational carbon and regenerative approaches towards energy and waste; and

3.1.8. Long life expectancy for buildings and infrastructure, using regenerative architectural principles.

3.2. Ensure that public financial support for the renovation and repurposing of existing buildings and the construction of new buildings is efficient, equitable, and sufficient to achieve the above goals, with priorities for funding being:

3.2.1. Māori and Pasifika housing solutions;

3.2.2. Providing healthy buildings;

3.2.3. Reducing climate change impacts;

3.2.4. Ensuring universal access and use for disabled people and older people;

3.2.5. Improving resilience against natural hazards (including managed retreat) and network utility outages;

3.2.6. Providing public housing to meet the needs of those who need to move due to climate change effects; and

3.2.7. Providing affordable housing.

3.3. Encourage residential development that:

3.3.1. Differs between city centres, urban suburbs, provincial towns, villages and rural areas;

3.3.2. Meets diverse housing needs in each neighbourhood;

3.3.3. Is adaptable to changing life stages and multi-generational living needs;

3.3.4. Reverses the trend of the increasing size and complexity of residential buildings;

3.3.5. Contributes to the vibrancy of the community;

3.3.6. Provides for food gardens and trees; and

3.3.7. Is oriented to the sun.

3.4. Improve oversight and coordination in the housing market by:

3.4.1. Establishing a Ministry for Green Works to ensure supply of suitable housing for all New Zealanders (along with broader goals to address the infrastructure deficit and the climate crisis) that, when building housing:

3.4.1.1. Acts with three arms: construction, design and oversight;

3.4.1.2. Sets a bold target for public housing that will achieve the urgent aim of accessible, healthy, secure and sustainable homes for all, including in rural towns and villages;

3.4.1.3. Works in conjunction with other areas of government to greatly increase government capacity to respond to interconnected challenges such as the housing and climate crises;

3.4.1.4. Has a board that ensures co-governance with Māori, prioritises the involvement of disabled people and includes workers and local government;

3.4.1.5. Partners with Māori organisations to provide Māori housing;

3.4.1.6. Is set up so it cannot acquire new land itself but can recommend the return of land to Māori;

3.4.1.7. Must take a long-term active role in solving the housing crisis, and not look to continue the current market-based approach; and

3.4.1.8. Will delegate management to Kāinga Ora or, if requested, to local councils with oversight from Kāinga Ora to ensure maintenance standards are met.

3.4.2. Creating an independent auditing body to ensure both new and existing buildings meet minimum modern standards.

3.5. Improve the energy efficiency of buildings by:

3.5.1. Raising mandatory energy efficiency standards in line with international best practices for new buildings, requiring all new builds to meet them, and developing a mechanism, incentives and a timeframe for retrofitting existing buildings to meet them;

3.5.2. Working with the building industry and research organisations to create a building energy performance rating system.

3.5.3. Establishing a requirement for residential and commercial buildings to carry an energy performance rating when put up for sale or rent.

3.5.4. Expanding advisory services and financial assistance to households to implement energy efficiency and conservation measures, including retrofitting inefficient homes and providing renewable energy options

3.6. Improve understanding of sustainable housing, by:

3.6.1. Researching effective ways to improve the sustainability and design of buildings, including construction methods designed for deconstruction and the reuse of building components;

3.6.2. Providing education and advocacy programmes on why and how to improve housing through renovations, repurposing and new builds;

3.6.3. Modelling sustainable building principles and high-quality design in all government buildings, including offices and public housing; and

3.6.4. Providing a low-cost public design and advice service for sustainable buildings.

A. Construction

3.7. Ensure that the market supplying building materials is working effectively in providing affordable, locally-produced materials for sustainable buildings, including by:

3.7.1. Breaking up building material supply monopolies, where necessary, and setting up publicly-run alternatives; and

3.7.2. Incentivising the use of wood and other construction materials low in embodied carbon for housing and for mid-rise buildings, and disincentivising the use of materials high in it.

3.8. Minimise construction waste by:

3.8.1. Removing barriers to reusing demolition materials in construction, including timber for structural purposes; and

3.8.2. Encouraging the relocation and renovation of existing timber houses where sites are being redeveloped and/or intensified, or where the existing house is at risk from natural hazards.

3.9. Ensure high-quality construction work by:

3.9.1. Reviewing construction contract law; and

3.9.2. Investigating mandatory insurance cover for poor construction, work not being completed, and to provide financial protection for subcontractors.

3.10. Enable the construction sector to deliver sufficient quality housing, including by:

3.10.1. Undertaking workforce planning and training for the construction sector; and

3.10.2. Building responsiveness to construction boom and bust scenarios into the public housing and building programmes to provide continuity of work for building industry workers.

4. Sustainable Communities

Issues

Poor quality urban environments reduce mobility, community engagement and belonging, and environmental sustainability. Gentrification of urban areas too often forces low-income residents out of the area or into substandard housing.

Actions

4.1. Support urban development that:

4.1.1. Creates vibrant, connected streets and public spaces at a human scale[1];

4.1.2. Equitably adopts universal urban design principles to ensure accessibility for disabled people;

4.1.3. Prioritises active and public transport over cars by design, with walkable[2] urban fabrics;

4.1.4. Promotes ecosystem health and community access to green space; and

4.1.5. Protects the rural-urban boundary and valuable food-growing soils.

4.2. Protect and restore nature in and around our cities by:

4.2.1. Taking an ecosystem-based approach to urban development;

4.2.2. Planting and protecting urban trees and urban ngahere;

4.2.3. Establishing guidelines for indigenous planting in urban areas, such as unused road strips, railway corridors, esplanade reserves and other areas;

4.2.4. Establishing green networks and ecological corridors through developed areas, including waterways; and

4.2.5. Prohibiting covenants that undermine positive environmental or social outcomes.

4.3. Equitably increase urban density by:

4.3.1. Reviewing and reducing the extent, scope and significance of 'special character areas', with a refocus that prioritises Māori heritage, natural heritage, and providing a strong heritage fabric;

4.3.2. Creating regulatory structures, including affordable housing requirements, that require developers to provide for equitable developments; and

4.3.3. Enabling a localised assessment of urban density and form with leadership by mana whenua and local government organisations.

4.4. Ensure that all New Zealanders, regardless of where they live, have access to all basic services in close proximity[3] including by:

4.4.1. Developing regional networks of towns and villages that are well connected by rail and have equitable internal transport;

[1] 'Human scale' means being readily relatable to the people who interact with it, and not being overbearing or massive.

[2] 'Walkable' means that a wide range of things you may want or need are within walking distance.

[3] 'Basic services' are those that are essential for wellbeing and participation in society, and include food, clothing, healthcare, education, training, phone/internet, community spaces, public transport

4.4.2. Encouraging equitable, mixed-use development of higher residential density close to urban centres and around public transport routes and infrastructure corridors, including through form-based zoning;

4.4.3. Supporting the use of redistributive policies such as inclusionary zoning[4].

4.5. Coordinate development and the provision of infrastructure that supports sustainable communities, including by:

4.5.1. Developing a National Policy Statement on Urban Design;

4.5.2. Developing proactive spatial plans for satellite cities with strong rail or rapid transit connections to major centres;

4.5.3. Developing national standards on mitigating natural hazard risks and climate change adaptation, such as managed retreat, for use when planning development in both urban and rural areas;

4.5.4. Establishing and maintaining an overview of housing needs; and

4.5.5. Including housing in the National Infrastructure Development Plan.

4.6. Support local communities to be included in decision-making on housing issues, especially minority or underserved groups, including by:[5]

4.6.1. Supporting the formation of regional housing forums as a means of collaboratively developing, implementing and monitoring design policy at the local level;

4.6.2. Establishing representative housing committees in all local communities that reflect both homeowners and renters;

4.6.3. Establishing public housing tenants' committees to give a collective voice to those living in public housing; and

4.6.4. When requested, allowing and resourcing regulated, non-profit community housing providers to collaboratively manage public housing.

4.7. Ensure sufficient housing in rural towns and villages to meet the needs of all generations over all life stages, including social, rental and assisted-living housing and papakāinga.

4.8. Support the development of co-housing and other communal housing approaches, including by:

4.8.1. Amending laws around private land ownership to enable co-operative models of land usage; and

4.8.2. Ensuring the Unit Titles Act remains up to date, promotes the sustainability of new apartment and multi-unit builds, and provides fair ownership and decision-making processes.

[4] 'Inclusionary zoning policies' are planning rules that require a given share of new construction to be affordable by people with low to moderate incomes

[5] 'Minority or underserved groups' in the housing context include Māori; disabled people; Pacific peoples; women; rainbow communities; migrant/ethnic communities; sole parents; renters; and low socio-economic communities throughout Aotearoa New Zealand.